

Who Does the Public Trust on Energy Issues?

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Introduction

In this paper, I examine the patterns of whom the US public trusts with regard to energy policy. Specifically, I use Latent Class Analysis (LCA) to demonstrate those patterns. Next, I examine how demographics and political beliefs are associated with specific classes of trust who are highly trusted. Finally, I explore if demographics, political beliefs, and classes of trusted actors are associated with concern regarding several energy policy issues.

Public Trust in Policy Actors

Data and Methods

Latent Class Analysis

Table 1: Fit statistics for competing latent class solutions (k = 2-9)

Classes (k)	BIC	AIC	Log-Likelihood	Entropy	Smallest Class (%)
2	84724.8	84356.2	-42117.1	0.854	39.9
3	81829.3	81273.3	-40544.6	0.851	14.1
4	79640.5	78897.1	-39325.6	0.853	15.5
5	78886.7	77956.0	-38824.0	0.847	9.2
6	78283.5	77165.5	-38397.7	0.845	8.7
7	77872.1	76566.7	-38067.4	0.832	8.5
8	77598.0	76105.3	-37805.7	0.835	7.5
9	77380.7	75700.7	-37572.3	0.836	6.3

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Results

Table 2: Latent class sizes

Class	N	Percent
Trust in Scientists & Environmental Groups	1035	33.2
Broad Institutional Trust	824	26.5
Generalized Low Trust	770	24.7
Deep Distrust of All Actors	484	15.5

Figure 1: Probability of high trust (7-10 on a 0-10 scale) in each actor, by latent class

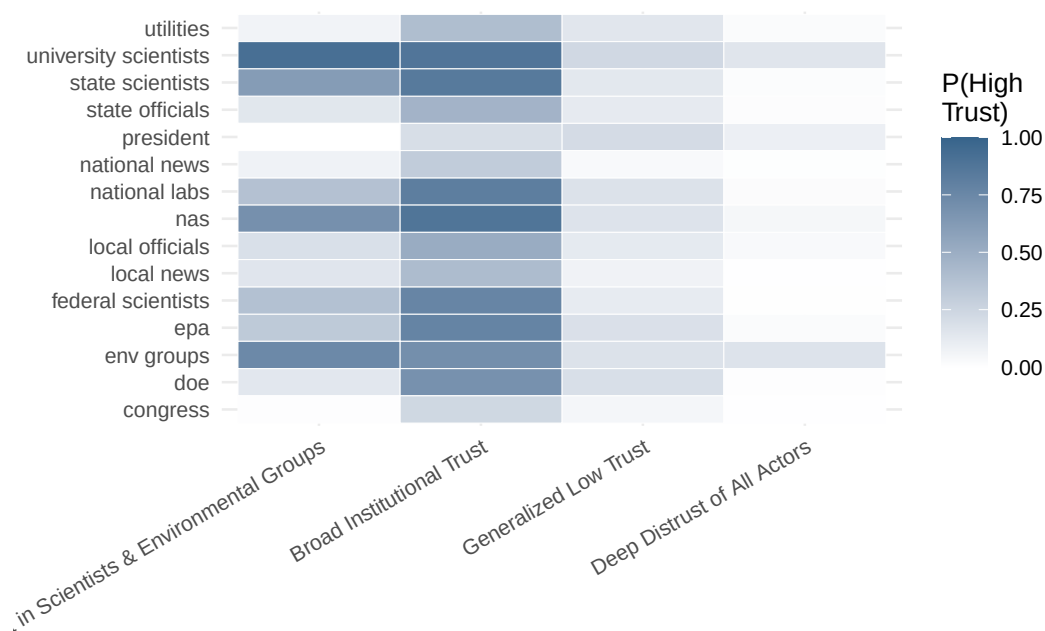


Table 3: Multinomial logit coefficient estimates predicting trust-class membership (reference class: Trust in Scientists & Environmental Groups, 33.2%). Standard errors are in parentheses.

	Broad Institutional Trust (26.5%)	Generalized Low Trust (24.7%)	Deep Distrust of All Actors (15.5%)
(Intercept)	-1.991*** (0.290)	-1.331*** (0.282)	-0.813** (0.296)
age	0.007* (0.003)	0.008* (0.004)	0.004 (0.004)
male	0.109	-0.205†	-0.179

Table 3: Multinomial logit coefficient estimates predicting trust-class membership (reference class: Trust in Scientists & Environmental Groups, 33.2%). Standard errors are in parentheses.

	Broad Institutional Trust (26.5%)	Generalized Low Trust (24.7%)	Deep Distrust of All Actors (15.5%)
white	(0.108) -0.425***	(0.113) -0.450***	(0.125) -0.186
college	(0.118) -0.034	(0.124) -0.234†	(0.138) -0.387**
inc	(0.114) 0.003	(0.122) -0.055*	(0.137) -0.086***
democrat	(0.021) 0.304	(0.023) -0.657***	(0.026) -1.247***
republican	(0.205) 0.693**	(0.193) 0.495*	(0.203) 0.351
trump.ap- proval	(0.235) 0.933***	(0.218) 1.083***	(0.224) 0.857***
	(0.079)	(0.079)	(0.082)
Num.Obs.	3113		
R ²	0.125		
R ² Adj.	0.119		
AIC	7510.4		
BIC	7673.6		
RMSE	0.40		
† p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001			

Table 4: Validity check: weighted regression predicting concern about pollution from trust-class membership

	Concern about Pollution
(Intercept)	7.856*** (0.266)
age	0.004 (0.004)
male	-0.516*** (0.112)
white	-0.124 (0.123)
college	0.224* (0.109)
inc	-0.034

Table 4: Validity check: weighted regression predicting concern about pollution from trust-class membership

	Concern about Pollution
	(0.021)
democrat	0.082
	(0.164)
republican	-0.831***
	(0.198)
trump.approval	-0.312***
	(0.065)
trust_classBroad Institutional Trust	0.118
	(0.137)
trust_classGeneralized Low Trust	-0.835***
	(0.153)
trust_classDeep Distrust of All Actors	-1.287***
	(0.199)
Num.Obs.	3113
R ²	0.194
R ² Adj.	0.191
AIC	15144.8
BIC	15223.4
RMSE	2.42
† p < 0.1, * p < 0.05, ** p < 0.01, *** p < 0.001	

Discussion

Conclusion

References